

The Reproduction of Stratified Labor in Fordist Michigan

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The Fordist revolution was a watershed moment in the history of capitalist production. It set, in the 1910s, a standard pattern of production that would be taken up across industries in the core regions of the capitalist world-economy. However, very few of the technical innovations attributed to Henry Ford actually originated in the Ford Motor Company. Political economist Simon Clarke notes that “the decomposition of tasks, the specialization of tools, the assembly of tools into the machine, and even of machines into the machine system” (Clarke 1990) were already common in US industry prior to Ford’s project – even the automated assembly line, Ford’s most notorious invention, was actually developed in 1911 by EMF Company, a rival automobile firm (Lichtenstein and Meyer 1988, 20). For Clarke, Ford’s real innovation was that he “applied these principles to a new branch of production ... with such single-minded ruthlessness that he transformed the conditions of production motor vehicles almost overnight.”

The ruthlessness with which Ford reconfigured the labor process was mirrored in his approach to controlling labor inputs. After the establishment of the moving assembly line and the consequent reconfiguration of the labor process, the primary remaining barrier to efficient production at Ford was employee turnover- 400% in 1913. In addition to training new workers hired to support growing production, Ford also was constantly training replacements for workers who left. With training costs between \$35 and \$100 for each new worker, Ford was hemorrhaging money that could not be recouped by suppressing wages (Lichtenstein and Meyer 1988, 54). Ford’s solution? Pay better. But not just better, *a lot better*. In January 1914, to the outrage of other regional employers, Ford doubled the salary of auto workers from \$2.50 to

\$5.00 a day. The name of this program, the “Five Dollar Day,” belies the scope of Ford’s concern with labor input: workers were only eligible for higher wages if they met certain moral standards in their daily lives, to be confirmed by a team of sociologists hired by Ford to investigate his employees. Ford’s management practices, as well as those of other automobile firms such as GM, intentionally blurred the line between work and private life: private life and the home came to be seen as an extension of the shop floor, crucial zones for the management of the relations of production and reproduction of capital.

There has recently been a wealth of scholarship on the social reproduction of the conditions of capital accumulation - both on a high theoretical level and in specific historical situations. In his book *Mute Compulsion*, dealing with the economic power of capital and its configuration of the “material conditions of social reproduction,” Søren Mau notes that he aims “not ... to offer an analysis of a historically or geographically particular variant of the capitalist mode of production” but to analyze “the ‘core structure’ or ‘ideal average’ of the capitalist mode of production” (Mau 2023, 5). Similarly, in her critique of Social Reproduction Theory, and particularly its blind-spot as regards the state, Kirstin Munro notes that, on the question of what exactly is being reproduced by reproductive workers, “understanding the cultural norms that prescribe working class ‘needs,’ the specific proportion of inputs, the social assignment of tasks, and the arrangement of people in space is an empirical question for historians” (Munro 2021, 624) – a task that she herself takes up elsewhere (Munro 2023).

In this paper I will examine the specific conditions of social reproduction in Fordist Michigan. The configuration of working-class life underwent a profound change at the beginning of the twentieth century, and industrial Michigan was, if not necessarily the epicenter of this change, at least one of its clearest examples. I am interested in the articulation of the relations of

reproduction in this specific historical situation, and especially the stratified and segregated ways in which specific types of labor were produced and reproduced in industrial Michigan. In other words, I ask not merely how labor power was reproduced, but how a matrix of stratified concrete labors was reproduced.

In choosing to focus on industrial Michigan, I am influenced by both the Marxist geography of Michael Storper and Richard Walker, and by the insights of world-systems analysts, especially Giovanni Arrighi. In his analysis of the rise of the US as global capitalist hegemony, Arrighi credits two aspects of American capitalism: the “internalization within a single organizational domain of activities and transactions previously carried out by separate businesses” (Arrighi 2010, 247) – that is, vertical integration – and a new relationship with space. Crucial to the rise of US hegemony, the country contained a massive internal frontier which in addition to providing rich reserves of labor and raw materials, required a material transformation of the relationship between capital and space: “as soon as the Revolution had freed the settlers’ hands, they set out to conquer as much of the North American continent as was profitable and to reorganize its space in a thoroughly capitalistic manner” (Arrighi 2010, 62).

Industrial Michigan was central to both of these developments in US capital accumulation. It sat at the entrance to the American west, and after the opening of the Eerie Canal Detroit was transformed into a crucial shipping port. Prior to the rise of the automobile industry, Michigan was at the center of US production in ship engines, rail-cars, and lumber – all industries crucial for the development of land west of the Mississippi river. The rail industry in the late 19th century, and especially the auto industry in the early 20th were established on the principle of vertical integration as a way to minimize transaction costs and maximize production. Most notorious is Ford’s River Rouge plant which turned raw materials into cars within a single

massive complex. For Storper and Walker, this was the “long wave of early Fordism” in which “the Midwest became the country’s industrial core led by the automobile ensemble centered on Detroit and the machine-tool complex focused on Chicago” (Storper and Walker 1989, 207).

My aim is to show that this historical shift in the relations of production was accompanied by very deliberate management of the conditions of the reproduction of labor power. This brings us to the central questions of this paper: what role does life outside the firm play in capitalist production, and how has capital attempted to exercise control over private life? To approach this question, we will look at the conditions of reproduction in industrial Michigan in the early decades of the Fordist revolution, paying special attention to the policies of both the Ford Motor Company in Detroit and its rival General Motors in nearby Flint. The Five Dollar Day, implemented by Henry Ford, and GM’s Modern Housing Corporation were both concerted efforts to reconfigure the relationship between public and private life, and to bring this relationship under the control of the capitalist firm.

The automotive industry in the midwest was not isolated from other industries or other regions. Before the dramatic ascent of Ford and General Motors, many regions of the US had thriving automotive industries. Many of these industries implemented social reproductive policies similar to those in Michigan - although usually on a smaller scale. Likewise, industrial firms were not the only agents in the reconfiguration of reproductive relations at the beginning of the twentieth century. A clear line can be drawn from the social-reproductive policies of Ford and GM and the welfare policies implemented by the federal government under Roosevelt. The specifics of social reproduction in Fordist Michigan are the local manifestation of a global dynamic, and as such can provide insight into the articulation between global trends and local forces.

To begin this examination, we need a theoretical apparatus upon which to hang our facts and figures. The work of Social Reproduction theorists, as elaborated in *Social Reproduction Theory* (Bhattacharya et al. 2017), provides such an apparatus. Bringing Social Reproduction Theory (SRT) to bear on our empirical study of labor reproduction in Fordist Michigan will have the additional effect of allowing us to identify both the strengths and limitations of SRT, or at least of Bhattacharya et al's formulation. The next section will trace SRT from its roots in the work of Lise Vogel to its current iteration, and will consider several criticisms of that iteration.

Social Reproduction Theory

Marxism and the Oppression of Women

Lise Vogel traces the beginnings of what would become Social Reproduction Theory (SRT) to debates among radical and socialist feminists in the 1960s and 1970s over women's liberation. Socialist feminists asserted that the patriarchy must be understood in relation to capitalism. Regardless of whether patriarchy and capitalism were to be seen as two interlocking systems of oppression or as a unified system, they insisted that the struggle for the liberation of women must be joined with the struggle for socialism. In her 1983 book *Marxism and the Oppression of Women*, Vogel argues "for the power of Marxism to analyse the issues that face women today in their struggle for liberation" but she "rejects, however, the assumption made by many socialists that the classical-Marxist tradition bequeaths a more or less complete analysis of the problem of women's oppression" (Vogel 2013, 2). Rather, she contends that the writings of Marx and Engels, as well as certain high-points in the twentieth century Marxist tradition, though they "never adequately addressed the question of women," contain the kernel of a theory that can be

developed into a “theoretical framework in which to situate the problems of women’s oppression and women’s liberation” (2).

Analyses of the problem of women’s oppression under capitalism fall within two broad camps. Vogel calls them “two essentially contradictory approaches,” (Vogel 2013, 134) the dual-systems perspective, and the social reproduction perspective. In the first approach, “women’s oppression derives from their situation within an autonomous system of sex-divisions of labor and male supremacy” (134). In other words, the oppression that women in modern society face *as women* differs from the oppression that they face on the basis of class. There are obviously overlaps and intersections between the two, but logically, “the dual-systems perspective implies that women’s oppression follows a course that is essentially independent from that of class oppression” (134). This has been the perspective of much radical feminism in the west, which has been at best agnostic towards anti-capitalism, and often hostile to it.

Vogel is more sympathetic to the social reproduction approach, although she considers it undertheorized. This approach grounds the oppression of women “in their differential position with respect to generational replacement-processes” (Vogel 2013, 135). This situates the analysis of the position of women in society within the “central dynamic of social development in societies characterized by exploitation” (135). As capitalism is a total social system, transforming every aspect of modern life, a historically grounded critique of the oppression of women must take as a central concern the drive for endless accumulation. As the exploitation of labor-power drives accumulation under capitalism, the social-reproduction approach to the so-called women-question examines the unique role of women in the production and maintenance of labor-power.

However, Vogel points to a much more fruitful analysis of social reproduction. Her book deals extensively with the history of Marxist approaches to the liberation of women, but in the last chapters, she interrogates the question itself: “the first requirement for further motion is to abandon the idea that the so-called women-question represents an adequate category of analysis” (Vogel 2013, 142). She elaborates the useful Marxist framework not as a theory of the position of women in society, but of the “reproduction of labour-power in the context of overall social reproduction” (142). Within this dynamic, women occupy contradictory positions for capital – on the one hand, the potential capacity to produce future workers is necessary for continued accumulation in the long term, but on the other hand bearing children reduces a person’s capacity to perform productive labor for capital: “childbearing potentially entails a costly decline in the mother’s capacity to work, while at the same time requiring that she be maintained during the period of diminished contribution” (Vogel 2013, 151).

Although her conception of ‘woman’ as simply those who have the capacity to bear children is perhaps dubious,¹ Vogel is making a broader point about gender and capital. For Vogel, women are oppressed in capitalist society due to their specific role in generational reproduction, i.e. the specific way in which they are dominated in service of the needs of capital. This consideration brings to the fore the articulation between productive labor and reproductive labor beyond just the question of childbearing. Reproduction entails not only the creation of new and future workers, but also the day-to-day maintenance of present workers and their dependents.

Vogel identifies this day-to-day reproductive labor as domestic labor. Though domestic labor is most often associated with feminized labor in private households, it “also takes place in

¹ For a theoretical critique of Vogel’s transhistorical association of the category of woman with the process of childbearing, see chapter 7 of *Mute Compulsion*, “Capitalism and Difference,” (Mau 2023, 152-173). For a historical explication of the contingent nature of this association, see *Patriarchy and Accumulation on a World Scale* by Maria Mies, especially chapter 3, “Colonization and Housewifization” (Mies 1986, 74-111).

labour-camps, barracks, orphanages, hospitals, prisons, and other such institutions” (Vogel 2013, 159). In other words, the oppression of women through the imposition of unwaged domestic labor is a specific manifestation of the larger phenomenon of reproductive labor within capitalism. Key to Vogel’s insight is that different forms of reproductive labor are utilized to reproduce different forms of labor. It is this larger phenomenon of social reproduction that has been elaborated in Social Reproduction Theory.

Social Reproduction Theory

Recent scholarship in Social Reproduction Theory has been collected in Tithi Bhattacharya’s edited volume, *Social Reproduction Theory: Remapping Class, Recentering Oppression*. The volume maps out a formidable project: to reclaim fully half of the capitalist system as an object of study for Marxism. In the introduction, Bhattacharya says that SRT “is an approach that is not content to accept what seems like a visible, finished entity – in this case, our worker at the gates of her workplace – but interrogates the complex network of social processes and human relations that produces the conditions of existence for that entity” (Bhattacharya 2017, 2). For SRT, this complex network, the relations of reproduction, are crucial for the functioning of capital, and they are fundamentally relations of human labor.

This formulation is in direct contradiction to the self-conception of capital, which “acknowledges productive labor for the market as the sole form of legitimate ‘work,’ while the tremendous amount of familial as well as communitarian work that goes on to sustain and reproduce the worker, or more specifically her labor power, is naturalized into nonexistence” (Bhattacharya 2017, 2). Indeed, Marx notes that value in capitalist societies is based not merely on labor-time, but on “socially necessary labor time” an abstraction that elevates the importance

of commodity producing labor and devalues all other types. The determination of what instances of labor are considered socially necessary is of course a contingent social process that responds to historical conditions. We will discuss this later in the paper, but for now it is enough to emphasize SRT's insight that to the extent that reproductive labor happens outside the realm of commodification, it is "analytically hidden by classical economists and politically denied by policy makers" (2).

Social Reproduction Theory, then, is a theory of this invisible reproductive labor, and an attempt to understand it as constitutive of capitalism. As its state of 'invisibility' would indicate, this is far from a simple task. Bhattacharya notes the distinction between public/private to delineate reproduction from production. The life of the worker is divided into two sections: the working day during which the worker is engaged in the production of value, and the space of reproduction, in which the laborers reproduce themselves, or at least their labor-power. The distinction is not so cut and dry, however. These spheres, though "they may be separate in a strictly spatial sense are actually united in both the theoretical and operational sense. They are *particular historical forms of appearance* in which capitalism as a process posits itself" (Bhattacharya 2017, 9). In fact, production and reproduction are quite messily intertwined.

Referencing an earlier article by Johanna Brenner and Barbara Laslett, Bhattacharya defines social reproduction as inclusive of "how food, clothing, and shelter are made available for immediate consumption, how the maintenance and socialization of children is accomplished, how care of the elderly and infirm is provided, and how sexuality is socially constructed" (Brenner and Laslett 1991, quoted in Bhattacharya 2017, 6-7). By this definition, reproductive labor includes the unpaid activity of mothers as well as waged nannies and daycare workers. It includes "unproductive" teachers in public education as well as "productive" teachers in private

schools. The network of reproductive relations is complex, pulsing just under the surface – unified by little other than its relation to labor-power and its devaluation by capital. It cuts across traditional Marxist understandings of labor: it includes both waged and unwaged work, it is sometimes commodified and sometimes not, it is performed by both men and women on both formal and informal bases, and it permeates all institutions of society from the home to the state itself.

The work in Bhattacharya's volume is at its strongest when it takes an expanded view not just of the types of labor required for capitalist accumulation, but of reproduction itself. This expanded view takes seriously Vogel's consideration of the reproduction of labor-power that takes place in "labour-camps, barracks, orphanages, hospitals, prisons, and other such institutions" (Vogel 2013, 159). Reproduction is far more than mere biological reproduction, though that is a crucial aspect. Labor-power is reproduced at several different levels of social organization – in addition to the family, Bhattacharya notes that "[s]lavery and immigration are two of the most common ways capital has replaced labor" (Bhattacharya 2017, 7-8). Societies can and have shifted the requirement to reproduce labor power from local families to the marginalized zones of the world, increasing the influx of workers to a region through invitation or theft. Additionally, the day-to-day reproduction of labor power in prisons and work-camps is performed not by family members, but by laborers themselves on an unwaged basis or by employees dedicated to reproduction, such as cooks or cleaners.

Capital has not, indeed cannot, commodify all aspects of reproduction. It may commodify aspects of care and subsume portions of the sphere of reproduction into production, but it requires as a foundation a matrix of unpaid and devalued life. Just what types of labor are commodified is historically contingent. Nancy Fraser's essay in *Social Reproduction Theory*,

“Crisis of Care” articulates this complex relation: “Historically, this work of ‘social reproduction’ has been cast as women’s work, although men have always done some of it too. Comprising both affective and material labor and often performed without pay, it is indispensable to society” (Fraser 2017, 21). Although the existence of this unpaid realm is crucial to the existence of capitalist accumulation, its boundaries are constantly shifting. In fact, its consolidation and denigration as “women’s work” has been a relatively recent (in historical terms) configuration: “Splitting off reproductive labor from the larger universe of human activities, in which women’s work previously held a recognized place, [industrial capitalist societies] relegated it to a newly institutionalized ‘domestic sphere,’ where its social importance was obscured” (Bhattacharya 2017, 24).

Fraser positions this domestic sphere not as a universal category, but a contingent one. It is identical neither to unpaid work, nor to reproductive work, but is the lever by which the relationship between unpaid work and reproduction is manipulated. Fraser treats the categories of SRT – domestic labor, reproduction, the family, etc. – not as fixed units of analysis, but as categories to be critiqued. How, specifically, have the configurations of production and reproduction been molded by the demands of value accumulation, and how have those configurations been constitutive of historical modes of capitalism?

Fraser tracks the shifting configuration of social reproduction through three eras of capitalism: the liberal capitalism of the nineteenth century, the state-managed capitalism of the early and mid 20th century, and the present moment of neoliberal financialization. In each of these periods, the relationship between production and reproduction was manipulated in order to relieve the tension of a systemic crisis. Liberal capitalism preferred a free labor market where the reproduction of labor power in the capitalist core was offloaded onto families, as production and

reproduction were forced into “separate spheres.” Drawing on Maria Mies notion of ‘housewifization,’ Fraser notes that this configuration of domestic labor in the core was dependent on the massive exploitation and denigration of women’s labor in the periphery.

After the ravages of the two great depressions in the 1870s-1890s and the 1930s, capitalist states reorganized the reproduction of labor-power on a model of state welfare. In this model, states assumed the burden of providing for reproduction, introducing in the US such measures as the minimum wage, social security, expanded public education and other programs of social protection and reproduction. State subsidization was limited, however. It was systematically withheld from workers in the periphery who were again exploited in order to subsidize social reproduction in the core. For the current moment of neoliberalization Fraser notes that there is “a new, dualized organization of social reproduction, commodified for those who can pay for it and privatized for those who cannot, as some in the second category provide care work in return for (low) wages for those in the first” (Fraser 2017, 32). Racialized immigrant workers are often employed in these low-waged domestic jobs – once again supporting the reproduction of other classes, but in this case often in a commodified manner.

At its best, SRT is a powerful critique of the foundations of the capitalist system: the too-often unpaid and devalued work of reproducing labor power. The consideration of reproductive labor as constitutive of capitalist accumulation is an important corrective to masculinist and wage-based analyses of capital. Although it is true that waged labor is crucial to the accumulation of value, the unpaid work of women and racialized men (and especially the work of abject laborers in the periphery) form the conditions of possibility of waged work. The continual devaluation of certain types of labor, especially reproductive labor, is the historical foundation of capitalism.

Critiques of Social Reproduction Theory

Too often, however, instead of investigating the complex relationship between production and reproduction, social reproduction theorists have committed to an overly rigid distinction between the two spheres. Although noting that they are part of the same complex of social relations, Vogel insists that “[r]eproduction of labor-power is not, however, itself a form of production” (Vogel 2013, 144). Similarly, in Bhattacharya’s formulation: “SRT points out that labor power itself is the *sole* commodity ... that is produced outside of the circuit of commodity production” (Bhattacharya 2017, 7). This is only partially true. Bhattacharya is correct that the reproduction of labor power requires activity outside of commodity production, but capital has always been interested in the commodification of reproductive care work. Activities of production and reproduction are not wholly distinct but overlap, and separating them so sharply reduces our ability to theorize, for example, the increasing privatization of reproduction. Capital, though required to offload some portion of the costs of reproduction onto unwaged workers or distant communities, has always retained a keen interest in the commodification of all life. When it has been able to afford producing the requirements of reproduction as commodities, it has done so.

This overly rigid circumscription of the reproductive sphere leads to some significant oversights in *Social Reproduction Theory*. The biggest shortcoming is the volume’s occasional credulous endorsement of the family as an intrinsically radical space due to its presumed logical separation from production. But the family is not merely an institution that has been harmed by capitalism – it is a fundamentally capitalist institution. When Mohandesi and Teitelman claim that “households have historically served as bulwarks against capitalism” (Mohandesi and

Teitelman 2017, 40) they accept at face value capitalism's paradoxical glorification of the family as a sacred space, untouched by crass commercialism. In fact, the family was formed by crass commercialism, and it exists in (or rather, was disciplined into) its modern form to perpetuate the conditions of reproduction.

The family, in its modern form, is not a transhistorical human organization, but a constituent institution of capitalist production. Immanuel Wallerstein, in his critique of traditional Marxist understandings of proletarianization, implicitly questions the highly idealized view of the family that would later be endorsed by some social reproduction theorists. Noting that capitalism requires and expands the condition of the alienated wage-labor through the historical process of proletarianization, Wallerstein insists that throughout the globe the object of this process has not been the individual wage worker, but the household or family unit. Throughout history, "individuals have tended to live their lives within the framework of relatively stable structures which share a common fund of current income and accumulated capital" (Wallerstein 1983, 23). These structures are generally (but not always) kin-based, and their boundaries are always shifting, in part due to the demands of the market: "It is in the context of such a household structure that a social distinction between productive and unproductive work began to be imposed on the working classes" (Wallerstein 1983, 24). In this formulation, the modern family is not a "bulwark against capitalism" but is an artifact of capital, formed by the pressures of accumulation.

For Wallerstein, the family/household structure plays two main roles in capitalist society. Its primary role is as an income aggregator. As an income pooling unit, the household structures various forms of contribution to the means of subsistence for its members: for Wallerstein income refers to waged income, but also cash transfers, petty commodity production, rent, and

subsistence activity. These five categories are combined in various proportions throughout the world, but generally wage-income is counterposed to the other four: Wallerstein considers households that depend primarily on wage-work to be proletarian households and considers those which depend primarily on other forms of income to be “semiproletarian households” (by far the larger group). Semiproletarian households are attractive to capitalists as “whenever wage-labor constitutes a substantial component of household income, there is necessarily a floor for how much the wage-earner can be paid” (Wallerstein 2004, 35).

The semiproletarian household organization is promoted by capital in most of the world, as the matrix of non-waged income acts as a subsidy to the reproduction of labor: the developed reproductive sphere depresses wages. However, there are two forces resisting semiproletarianization. “One is the pressure of the wageworkers themselves who seek to be ‘proletarianized,’ because that in effect means being better paid” (Wallerstein 2004, 35). Working families throughout the history of capitalism have preferred family structures that require less unremunerated reproductive labor and have struggled for this in unions and social movements. The second pressure comes from employers themselves, who have a “collective [long-term] need to have a large enough effective demand in the world-economy to sustain the market for their products” (35). In Wallerstein’s conception, we see the family as a site of many conflicting tensions, but also as a structure that has been organized to aid capitalist accumulation.

For Wallerstein, the household/family construct’s second role in capitalist society is as the site of ideological reproduction. He argues that:

Households serve as the primary socializing agencies of the world-system. They seek to teach us, and particularly the young, knowledge of and respect for the social rules by which we are supposed to abide. They are of course seconded by state agencies such as schools and armies as well as by religious institutions and the media. But none of these comes close to the households in actual impact. (Wallerstein 2004, 37)

This socialization plays an important role in conditioning future (and present) workers to accept their role as either paid laborers or subsistence laborers, and “results in the internalization of the myths, the rhetoric, and the theorizing of the system” (37). Wallerstein notes that occasionally this socialization can have an anti-systemic orientation, as households often “socialize members into rebellion, withdrawal, and defiance,” however, “antisystemic socialization can be useful to the system by offering an outlet for restless spirits, provided that the overall system is in relative equilibrium.” Further, except in times of structural crisis, “negative socializations may have at most a limited impact on the functioning of the system.”

Wallerstein’s work, and the work of world-systems analysts in general, has rarely entered direct conversation with social reproduction theorists. Their categories of analysis are different, household instead of family, and waged vs unwaged work instead of productive vs unproductive labor. However, Kirstin Munro has developed an explicit critique of SRT that mirrors some of Wallerstein’s concerns, though looking beyond the household/family structure to the entire matrix of social reproduction. Munro’s critique is based in the claim that “Social Reproduction Theory overlooks the contradictory and antagonistic role of the state in the lives of people, as the reproduction of labor power in capitalism proceeds via antagonism and state repression” (Munro 2021, 623). Not only is the household itself a site of ideological reproduction, as Wallerstein has pointed out, but the entire matrix of reproductive labor, whether performed for a wage or not, reproduces *specific types of labor*. Munro notes that the social role of reproductive and care workers such as nurses, teachers, and social workers “is the reproduction of not just any ‘life’ but that of a docile, exploitable worker” (624). When this labor is done by workers employed by the state, it represents not the state’s interest in the wellbeing of its subjects, but its interest in reproducing the specific types of labor historically necessary for the accumulation of capital.

Munro gives primacy to what Wallerstein called the “secondary institutions” of socialization – hospitals, schools, and social work organizations among others. These institutions are generally a part of the state, although private versions of them exist in growing numbers. Though ‘unproductive’ in the sense that it does not produce commodities, the labor performed by workers in hospitals, schools and social work agencies serves a valuable role for capital: it disciplines the labor of others. Though the aid this work provides is necessary for the survival of many working class families, Munro highlights what she perceives as the complicity of these laborers in state repression. In particular, she rejects the characterization of the labor done by these workers as virtuous “life-making,” preferring a more complicated formulation that situates the type of life being made within “a larger process that perpetuates the capitalist organization of society” (Munro 2021, 625). Indeed, “if exploitation and domination are inherent to the organization of production and reproduction in capitalism, then the reproduction of capitalist society proceeds by perpetuating these forms of organization” (625).

Munro’s critique of Social Reproduction Theory provides the impetus for the investigation central to this paper. While welcoming the achievement of SRT in its attempt to “overturn Marxist orthodoxy and shed light on the importance of unproductive labor carried out by disproportionately women of all races and racialized men” (Munro 2021, 623), she rejects the uncritical view of the reproductive sphere and care-work as virtuous or revolutionary that is common (though not universal) in the writing of social reproduction theorists. In positioning the reproductive sphere as constitutive of capitalist accumulation and complicit in the repression of workers, she opens up the following question: How have the specific historical configurations of the reproduction of labor power – “the cultural norms that prescribe working class ‘needs,’ the specific proportions of inputs, the social assignment of tasks, and the arrangement of people in

space” (Munro 2021, 624) – been manipulated to fulfill the specific historical need of capital for certain types of workers.

This brings me to my final point of emphasis: the uneven nature of reproduction across tasks, people, and space. We have pointed out that the claim by SRT that labor power is produced “outside the circuit of commodity production” is only partially true. Indeed, Marx notes in volume 1 of *Capital* that “the ultimate or minimum limit of the value of labour-power is formed by the value of the commodities which have to be supplied every day to the bearer of labour-power, the man, so that he can renew his life-process” (Marx 1976, 276). The value of labor power is, as for all other commodities, defined precisely by the extent to which it can be produced within the circuit of commodity production. This overlap between production and the reproduction of labor power is crucial because it represents an axis on which the value of labor power can be manipulated. If the value of the commodities required for renewing life-processes can be cheapened by the offloading of reproductive labor to unpaid or underpaid workers, then the value of labor drops as well.

The process devaluing labor by increasing the burden of uncommodified domestic work is not applied evenly to the working classes. Capital may value commodities based on an abstraction of undifferentiated labor power in various amounts, but it requires for the production process concrete acts of labor in various configurations and at various prices. Treating labor power as an undifferentiated mass may help us understand the logic of exploitation in a society based on generalized exchangeability, but in order to understand the historical configuration of production and reproduction in a given time and place, we must disaggregate this mass into its component parts. In other words, to build off Munro’s critique, what is reproduced by domestic

and unproductive laborers is not merely life, or even labor power, but the specific kinds of concrete labor required by capital.

In the remaining sections of this paper, we will return to industrial Michigan. As the Fordist revolution changed the way that capital is produced, it was accompanied by a revolution in the relations of reproduction. We will examine the extension by capital of new types of control over the private lives of workers in an attempt to tease out how specific configurations of household reproduction supported the new productive regime.

Reproduction in Action

Prior to the Great Depression, automotive manufacturing was widespread in the US, especially in the midwest and northeast although there were also firms on the west coast. However, the production innovations that originated in Ford plants and that were picked up and improved upon by firms such as General Motors or Ransom Olds were less widespread and after the Great Depression 50% of motor vehicle manufacturers had closed (Bresnahan and Raff 1991). The Big Three automakers headquartered in Michigan - Ford Motor Company, General Motors, and Chrysler - emerged as the dominant forces in the industry. In this section we will explore the conditions of the reproduction of labor in Detroit and Flint that contributed to their success during the first decades of the Fordist revolution. I hope to highlight what I see as two important institutions through which industrial employers took control of the realm of private life – Ford Motor Company's Five Dollar Day, and GM's housing subsidiary the Modern Housing Corporation. The first is well studied, but we will be looking to the extent that the Five Dollar Day was generalized among Detroit workers, and the types of household formations that it influenced. The second is less represented in the literature, and so we will rely on a combination

of archival documents and secondary literature. We will look at the time period stretching roughly from 1910, just three years before Henry Ford's assembly line, to 1930 and the collapse of the global economy.

At the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th, American industry underwent significant changes. After the civil war in the US, waves of workers moved both north and west, whether Black workers looking for relief from the racial regime of the American south, or white workers from the northeast looking for new opportunities in the west. Although the Midwest, and Michigan in particular, had been a destination for immigrants looking for work since the late 18th century, the population virtually exploded in the twentieth. From 1910 to 1930, in just twenty years, the population of Michigan almost doubled from 2.8 million to 4.8 million residents. Michigan's cities saw the greater portion of this boom as the Michigan economy shifted from extractive industries such as logging and copper mining to craft production and manufacturing. In the same time period, Detroit more than tripled to over 1.5 million inhabitants, and Flint more than quadrupled to 150,000 (U.S. Census Bureau 1940).

Much of this growth was driven by two demographic sources: European immigrants (listed as "foreign-born whites" in the censuses) with high birth rates, and Black workers looking for better working conditions than were available to them in the American south. While the mass migration of willing (and as-yet un-unionized) workers was welcomed by employers, it created several real problems. There were simply more people moving to and living in the cities than could be comfortably housed with existing housing stock, and these new workers were unused to industrial work and the lifestyles expected of them.

The change in the nature of work and in the demographic composition of workers led to the development of new social institutions, as well as the rise of overcrowded slums in industrial

cities. In the 1890s, Congress allocated funds for an investigation into the country's developing slums as a response to "civic leaders and voluntary associations [crying] out for action to improve the housing and surroundings of the 'new Americans' from Europe, and of the native poor" (Scott 1969, 7). This investigation was one of the first steps toward the development of city planning, and was part of a concerted effort "aimed at abolishing sweatshops, strengthening the labor movement, providing more manual and trade instruction, and improving education" (Scott 1969, 11).

The federal government would begin to play a larger part in providing for the welfare of its citizens during the Great Depression, with the bundle of social programs included in Roosevelt's new deal, but prior to that much of the work of dealing with the overcrowding and immiseration of urbanites was left to local and corporate actors. In Detroit in the 1920s, the "Detroit Bureau of Governmental Research, a private organization ... worked with a Mayor's Committee on Finances in estimating future increases in municipal revenues" in order to fund public services (Scott 1969, 255). Even so, in 1927 the Detroit City Planning Commission and the Michigan Housing Association conducted "a series of surveys of Detroit and found 'what was to be expected' - that juvenile delinquency, deaths from tuberculosis and pneumonia, infant mortality, crime, and dependency were more prevalent in the blighted areas than they were in other parts of the city" (Scott 1969, 256). A major goal of the early automobile manufacturers was to insulate their workers from this blight, and so they developed private institutions of social control.

Immigrant workers coming from agricultural regions of the American South and Eastern Europe had to be actively conditioned to the industrial life of the Midwest. If Fordism was at its core the "transformation of production, according to strict criteria of technical rationality" then it requires for that transformation "new forms of social stratification, in strict accordance with the

technical function, and corresponding new forms of morality and of personality, of socialization and education, to ‘elaborate a new type of man suited to the new type of work and productive process’” (Clarke 1990). Gramsci refers to this social elaboration of a stratified society oriented towards the rationalization of work as ‘Americanism’ – imbricated with Fordism, but fundamentally distinct.

There are two aspects of Gramsci’s concept of Americanism that are crucial to our present project – its historical specificity and its function as the mechanism of social differentiation. Although he welcomed the application of Fordist principles to European production, Gramsci was skeptical of the possibility of establishing Americanism in Europe as it requires a fundamental preliminary condition. “This condition could be called ‘a rational demographic composition’ and consists in the fact that there do not exist numerous classes with no essential function in the world of production, in other words classes which are purely parasitic” (Gramsci 1971, 281). European society, for Gramsci, is characterized precisely by the existence of ‘parasitic’ classes with no economic function beyond consumption.

This brings us to the second point of interest in Gramsci’s schema – Americanism is not a system of reducing stratification by the elimination of parasitic classes, but is the creation of a new configuration of stratified society in which every social class is defined by its relation to production. For industrial Michigan, the massive waves of immigration in the early 20th century, although posing the problems of overcrowding and resource strain, provided the perfect opportunity for an experiment in Americanism. Families from Europe and individual workers from the American South, in looking for life and work, were funneled into different types of both. In our glance at the social patterns emerging in industrial Michigan, we will see that the

different types of life created and reproduced correspond to the different types of work required by local industry.

The Five Dollar Day – Patterns of Work

Enter the Five Dollar Day. As mentioned previously, the Five Dollar Day was a significant pay increase for skilled workers at Ford Motor Company designed to combat the region's high turnover rates. As most of the new laborers available to Ford came from agricultural backgrounds, training costs were so exorbitant that a 100% increase in wages was justified if it significantly reduced turnover. However, the Five Dollar Day was much more than just a raise. Half of the pay was categorized as a profit sharing scheme in which workers only qualified to participate if they met "specific standards of efficiency and home life" (Meyer 1981, 6). As a part of this program, Ford employed a team of sociologists to ensure that employees spent their free time appropriately, and through his English school the Ford Motor Company "attempted to change an immigrant worker's life and culture to its preconceived ideal of an 'American standard of living,' which it felt was the basis for industrial efficiency" (6).

Ultimately the Five Dollar Day was short-lived, interrupted by rising inflation and labor problems associated with the First World War. However, despite its early demise, it retains an outsized significance as an "early managerial strategy to match working-class culture to the requirements of the modern factory" (Meyer 1981, 7). But the 'modern factory' is not the whole of production, and even within the factory, labor and pay were not evenly distributed by this program. Although there was little pay variation based on race within the Ford factories, Black workers were segregated by job type. They may have received similar pay to whites, but in order to do so they had to work in "hot, dangerous foundry jobs where quit rates were generally high"

(Foote et al 2003). In other words, Black workers were forced into the most precarious and dangerous jobs in order to preserve both the lives and careers of white workers. Even when Black workers received the same pay rate as their white peers, their labor was fundamentally ancillary.

The Five Dollar Day was never evenly applied to an entire population of workers. Kathleen Stanley and Joan Smith, in their study of the household in Detroit at the turn of the century, claim that “the crucial element of Fordism was the presumption of the so-called family wage – a male earned wage sufficient for the support of a dependent wife and children. However, in fact, even in Detroit, this presumed bastion of Fordism, the family wage was never really a reality for the majority of wage earners” (Stanley and Smith 1992, 34). Rather, the majority of working families relied on supplemental income from wives and children, as well as significant subsistence labor. Moreover, after the economic collapse in 1929, working families depended increasingly on direct assistance from the state.

Stanley and Smith convincingly portray the position of households in Detroit as a textbook case of partial proletarianization. Although employers required wage laborers in increasing numbers for industrial production, they were loath to pay the full cost of that labor’s reproduction. And so the burden of reproducing labor at the level of the household was meted out to various actors. If we follow Marx’s analysis of the value of labor-power, then the Five Dollar Day, as it was granted only to portions of the working class, did not represent a general increase in the value of labor-power, but a new stratification of the value of labor-power. If the renewal of the life processes of some class of laborer can be supplied outside the commodity sphere by unpaid or devalued subsistence labor, then the value of labor-power for that class of laborer falls.

This stratification is reflected in the structure of Detroit households. Stanley and Smith look at three types of families: US-born white families, Polish families (as representative of white immigrant workers), and Black families. In 1920, wives and mothers in white immigrant families were the least likely to work outside the home (about 1 in 20), and their children most likely. US-born white women worked at rates that were slightly higher, but “still quite low,” and their children were the most likely to stay in school. Stanley and Smith consider that the difference in family makeup between these two groups result from the higher wages of US-born white men, “72 percent of whom were either professional or skilled workers,” and because “Polish families brought with them skills associated their recent past as peasants” such as the practice of women keeping livestock and gardens (Stanley and Smith 1992, 38).

While the differences in household structure between immigrant families, and the families of American-born whites were far from negligible, they paled in comparison to their shared differences with Black families. Unlike US-born whites with existing family structures in Michigan and white European immigrants, who usually migrated as family units, Black workers more often migrated as individuals with no family or community contacts. The mass arrival of single Black workers was “a strong encouragement to the phenomenon of boarding, which helped both the new migrants and old residents to hold down housing costs” (Stanley and Smith 1992, 46). While boarding, or the inclusion of non-family members in a household, was extant among all ethnic groups, it was almost required in Black households as most Black laborers were unskilled and received wages far below the subsistence level. Boarding was, for Black households, a strategy of survival. It was at once a result of the devaluation of Black labor in Detroit, and the conditions for the continuation of that devaluation.

Although boarding increased a household's cash flow via an extra wage-earner, it also required an increase in the demand of domestic subsistence labor, usually performed by women. Indeed, "in larger households, the addition of at least one woman boarder became necessary at certain points simply to share in the additional housework" (Stanley and Smith 1992, 47). The increased domestic service load for Black women is illuminating when compared with white families within Detroit and Black families in other cities. Although married Black women worked outside the home at approximately half the rate within Detroit as Black women in other cities, they had outside work at five times the rate of immigrant whites: "In 1920, one in four married Black women worked for wages compared to only one in twenty married immigrant women" (46). Moreover, just as their burden of unpaid domestic labor was increased at home due to boarders, their waged labor outside the home was also domestic service. Black women were underrepresented in all occupations except service: whereas white women worked in not-insignificant numbers in manufacturing, trade, professional service and clerical work, 88% of Black women working outside the home in Detroit were employed as personal servants (U.S. Census Bureau 1930, 805). This is not to say that white women did not experience foreclosed employment opportunities relative to white men, but rather that the employment of Black women was overdetermined by both their race and their gender.

Home and communal life

The working conditions of Detroit workers were inseparable from their living conditions. One of the most significant objects of Ford's sociological investigation, and pre-requisite for increased pay, was workers' communal and private life. Sociologists working for the company would drive into working class neighborhoods and find neighbors, friends, and family members

to vouch for the employee's character. Stephen Meyer notes that "the company held the worker responsible and accountable for the outside witnesses to his character. 'In cases where it is impossible to find someone who knows the habits and home life of the employee,' the home office instructed Ford branches, 'we withhold the increase [in profits] otherwise to be granted him under the plan'" (Meyer 1981, 130). This would not necessarily be an issue for families with generations-long roots in the city, or for white European workers who migrated with their families, but for single Black migrant workers, or workers whose wives and children were forced to work outside the home, this amounted to almost an automatic disqualification.

Workers were also judged on their living conditions, with properly maintained homes factoring heavily into the judged fitness of a worker to receive higher wages. Meyer recounts a story of a German Catholic worker who was investigated by Ford's sociologists, and rejected from the profit share:

He lived in a two-story frame house that was in "poor condition." The neighborhood was also unacceptable: "Very bad. This is an alley with one and two storey houses in poor condition on one side only. Foreign." The investigator detailed his impressions of the Ford worker's standard of living: "This man lives in a dirty unsanitary hut and has a room full of boarders, who sleep 3 and 4 to a room. Some of the boarders go through the room where the man and wife sleep to reach their own room. Wife looks haggard from overwork. She and the children are as dirty as their surroundings."

Living under such conditions, the investigator did not approve the worker for a share in the profits. Instead, he "advised" the worker not to have boarders, to move to a better neighborhood, and generally to improve his living conditions.

Even having boarders was considered a sign of unfitness, an inability to manage one's home. The worker in this anecdote eventually received his part of the profit share, but only when he had evicted his boarders, moved to the suburbs, and (on his own meager salary) built a free-standing single family home. Labor that is supported by certain household and reproductive configurations was explicitly devalued, which then reinforced the need for those configurations.

This anecdote brings us to what I consider to be the most powerful factor in social stratification, and one of capital's greatest tools in disciplining the conditions of reproduction: housing, and its corollary, residential segregation.

Racial and residential segregation are extreme forms of social stratification. In industrial Michigan, residential segregation allowed for the housing shortage caused by increased immigration to be addressed on a differential basis – more of the limited resources available to cities could be directed towards housing more 'valuable' populations. Of course, racial segregation was not invented in 20th century Michigan – it had been a crucial element of colonial policy for hundreds of years. Carl H. Nightingale notes that the words "white town" and "black town," designating the sectors of a divided city, were first used by colonial city officials in Madras in South India (2012, 47). This pattern was copied and reinforced by states and municipalities throughout the world for centuries, separating people of European ancestry from those they viewed as unequal. In the US, however, by the early 20th century, "black activists and their allies were able to convince the US Supreme Court to invalidate residential race segregation by government legislation" (296). The state did, of course, still pass racial legislation such as race-based immigration restrictions and lending policies, but it was no longer able to formally enforce the residential color line with direct legislation.

In order to work around this federal restriction, segregationists "reformulated the crusade for urban color lines in the United States. They culled a set of ideologies and city-splitting tools from the two other global-scale sources of institutional power used by urban segregation movements elsewhere – urban reform politics and the real estate industry" (296). This allowed for the creation of overcrowded slums to house poor and non-white residents, separated from the well-served affluent neighborhoods of skilled white workers and managers. In industrial

Michigan, the institutions of segregation were developed by private industry, providing the state with a blueprint to continue the maintenance of a stratified society through indirectly selective welfare.

From 1910 to 1930, as Detroit more than tripled in size, the Black population grew from 5,741 to over 120,000 – a 20x increase. Many of these workers had lost jobs with the mechanization of southern agriculture and were moving to the Midwest, where manufacturing was booming. However, what awaited them was a potent combination of second-rate jobs and derelict neighborhoods. Mark Jay and Philip Conklin note that Black workers were forced into the “worst paid, most degrading, and most dangerous work Blacks were largely confined to jobs as production assistants, janitors and foundry workers.” This was reflected in housing, as “African Americans were also forced to live in the segregated Black Bottom neighborhood, which contained the city’s worst housing stock, often owned by predatory absentee landlords” (Jay and Conklin 2020, 84).

It is well known that Black workers were forced to live in a state of segregation and abjection, and that they were often forced into bad jobs or paid less than their white peers. However, the connection between these phenomena is more complicated than it initially appears to be. Analysis of Detroit, both its history and its present, often centers a two-city hypothesis – one Detroit is a slum, and the other a great economic boomtown. However, Jay and Conklin argue that the “‘Two Detroits’ consensus in fact represents two components of a dialectical unity: redevelopment and austerity are not distinct processes but *two elements of the same process of uneven development*” (Jay and Conklin 2020, 14). They are writing of the recent gentrification, but the divided city has always been a complete, if contradictory, whole.

Looking at the relationship between housing and demographic trends in employment, we begin to see how segregation served city employers, and particularly how residential segregation assisted in the process of Americanization. In Detroit in 1930, Black men were significantly underrepresented in trades and in professional service (architects, doctors, lawyers etc.) relative to their population, and significantly overrepresented in domestic and personal service. In manufacturing as a whole, Black workers were employed consistent with their relative population, but were largely absent from highly paid or skilled positions such as foremen, managers, or even machinists. Instead they were overrepresented in low-paid laborer positions: over a third of Black male industrial workers were employed as unskilled laborers for automobile factories, as opposed to less than 10% of US-born whites. When we speak of the socialization of new workers, it is clear that they were being socialized into different strata of the working class, separated largely by their race and reinforced by housing and household patterns.

The Modern Housing Corporation

In nearby Flint, Michigan, General Motors took a different approach to Americanism than Ford's Five Dollar Day, one that more explicitly emphasized housing as crucial to the elaboration of social stratification. This approach centered around the Modern Housing Corporation, a subsidiary of GM that purchased lots of land, developed them with houses and amenities and then sold them directly to employees. In a retrospective report, written by a "Mr. Cowdrick" in 1930, the Modern Housing Corporation was created to conduct "all the more important housing activities" of GM (Cowdrick 1930, 1). These activities included the acquiring or building of more than 4,000 homes and 54 non-residential buildings, the vast majority in Flint, Michigan, but a small number also in Pontiac, Lansing, and Janesville, Wisconsin. The project was initiated

in 1919 to combat limited housing due to “the expansion of automobile manufacture in the years immediately following the World War,” and ran until it was dissolved in 1936. It seems to have always been viewed as a short term project to resolve a discrete problem, rather than a long term undertaking, as Mr. Cowdrick notes in 1930 that it “is expected that when all the properties have been liquidated, probably about 1945, all expenses will have been paid and the company will have recovered all the money it put into the project, but without interest” (4). That the corporation was liquidated 9 years before Mr. Cowdrick’s prediction hints at who was expected to continue the project: the global economic crisis of the 1930s saw the state take over the management of the social status quo to an unprecedented degree.

Indeed, direct return on investment seems to have been less of a concern for the Modern Housing Corporation than developing a pattern that others would follow. The small profit made on each house in the project’s mature years, mostly funded the salaries of project administrators. After taxes and interest, if the company is to be believed (which is a big “if,” to be sure), it “about ‘[broke] even’ on its expenditures” (Cowdrick 1930, 4). For the first several years of the project homes were sold at a loss, and for the length of the project, “at the time a house [was] sold, the Modern Housing Corporation ... secure[d] a mortgage from an outside lender” (3), reducing the burden of capital outlay, but also significantly reducing the potential financing profits.

If the only problem was a housing shortage, then there were far more simple and far more profitable solutions than the Modern Housing Corporation. But when we understand the goal to be parallel to Ford’s desire to “elaborate a new type of man,” – or, drawing on Gramsci, to elaborate a new type of stratified society – then the efficacy of the Modern Housing Corporation is obvious. General Motors saw in the rapid growth of the auto industry and the rapid growth of

Flint an opportunity to completely restructure the conditions of reproduction for life and capital. Flint's population was about 13,000 in 1900 and increased more than tenfold in thirty years. This forced Flint to consider where and how to house the new workers, but more importantly, it had to decide what kind of city it would become. Tied up with this was the question of who would make the decisions about Flint's future, and who would provide the capital to fund the necessary development? The obvious answer seemed to be that Flint's biggest employer would fill both of these roles, and General Motors took to the task with enthusiasm. This was not just a chance to build houses for workers, but a chance to fundamentally shape every aspect of their lives.

General Motors did not create its housing division solely for the purpose of alleviating population issues, nor was the Modern Housing Corporation a venture into conventional real estate investment. The project was explicitly one of Americanization. Mr. Cowdrick's report hints at the scope of the project. The homes sold to employees were not placed outside of cities in small company owned communities, but were "inside the limits of cities or large towns" (Cowdrick 1930, 5). This provided the communities with "the benefits of customary municipal services, including police and fire protection and sanitary regulations," (5) at little to no cost to General Motors, but it also gave GM enormous leverage over the geography of the city itself.

Framed as General Motors' cooperation "with the public authorities for the benefit of the homeowners" (Cowdrick 1930, 5), the Modern Housing Corporation's community administration plan was a collaboration with the municipality to allocate city resources to serve GM employees. GM would make initial investments into public infrastructure that would then be taken over either by the city or by homeowners themselves. After an early contractor paid for the initial pavement of "about ten miles of streets ... a considerable amount of additional paving has been laid at the expense of the property owners." Additionally, the corporation planted trees

along the streets, and noted that “home owners generally seem to be interested in improving their property and keeping it in good condition.”

General Motors’ administration of the Modern Housing Corporation showed a strong commitment to ensuring that employees had access to benefits far beyond mere housing stability. The corporation donated or purchased land for public schools, effectively choosing who would have ready access to education: “At Flint, there is one grade school and one junior high school inside the Modern Housing development Another grade school is contemplated, and will be located inside the Modern Housing development” (Cowdrick 1930, 5). To add to this, schoolteachers were one of the few non-employee groups who were allowed to purchase homes in the Modern Housing developments. In addition to considerations for education, the corporation “laid out and improved a golf course and presented it to the city. It also erected a community building for donation to the city.” The golf course and community center were both public and although they were built by the corporation, they were maintained at the expense of the city.

From the first five pages of Mr. Cowdrick’s report, Flint seems like the apogee of the American dream: well-paid workers living with their families in owned homes on tree-lined streets; readily accessible public parks and community centers; schools and communities where teachers are given privileged status. One can imagine why Flint’s population quadrupled from 1910 to 1930. But as we know, this dream was built on uneven ground. The last paragraph of the report starts: “The regulations provide that houses may be sold only to members of the Caucasian race” (6). Just as in Detroit, the project of Americanism was not the creation of a more affluent class of workers, but the reconfiguration of a stratified working class.

Whites, especially well-employed whites, were encouraged to live in the well-served company communities, but GM did not create designated neighborhoods for Black and other non-white workers. They were segregated by default, by exclusion. Although the Modern Housing Corporation was explicitly developed to address the city of Flint's inability to house its growing population, it did nothing to help the fastest growing demographic: Black workers. While the white population almost quadrupled from 1910 to 1930, the Black population increased more than fourteen-fold. By default, these Black migrants looking for a place to live were consigned, along with poor white families, to "informal working-class settlements, most of which lacked urban amenities such as parks, sewers, and paved roads" (Highsmith 2015, 28). Described by the city building inspector as "shanty towns," these unserved and informal suburbs were "more gritty and undeveloped than those in many other metropolitan areas" (28). These neighborhoods were simultaneously the poorest, most racially diverse, and least served by city resources.

General Motors' project of Americanism was not a uni-directional imposition of norms: rather the makeup of the town and the makeup of the company were co-constituted. GM sold houses to their best men, and then praised the men for their responsible homeownership, stating that "theoretically, foremen and superintendent do not favor customers of the Modern Housing Corporation in selecting men for retention, when reductions in force are necessary, but it is probable that the fact of home ownership exercises some influence" (6). Even when a homeowner lost their job, they were given support by GM to keep their homes until they could resume making mortgage payments. The implication is clear: the valued worker is a homeowner, and a homeowner makes for a good worker. But this positive assertion of the value of a worker and their home life was predicated on the devaluation of a large mass of unskilled labor – and the

consequent degradation of Black and poor neighborhoods. As GM funneled city funds and services to their Modern Housing developments, ultimately it was marginalized families that paid the price.

Conclusion

What emerges from this soup of demographic data is a complex hierarchy of labor that does not fit neatly into categories of waged/unwaged and productive/unproductive. A given type of work could fit into any combination of the above categories depending on who was performing it. Housework is unwaged and unproductive labor if done by a housewife to feed her family, or by a worker in their free time, but it becomes both waged and productive if performed on a waged-basis by a domestic servant hired on the open market. The physical act of the housework is identical in either case; the only change is the social context in which it is performed. The same could be said for cooking meals, or growing food, or teaching: it is not the act itself, but the social context of the act that determines its relationship to capital accumulation.²

In all of these scenarios, whether productive or not, the labor is reproductive. A worker needs clean clothes, a full belly, and skill in order to “arrive at the doors of her place of work every day so that she can produce the wealth of society” (Bhattacharya 2017, 1). Sometimes these necessities are provided by the market, sometimes they are extracted from unpaid laborers, or from the devalued work of racialized communities. That the requirements of the reproduction of labor cannot be so easily disaggregated from the results of production does not mean that the sphere of “social reproduction” is incoherent. Rather, I think that social reproduction is a crucial category of analysis precisely because it is not simply the negative space of production: it is both

² For the question of whether service can be considered a commodity, and therefore whether service work can be considered productive labor, see (Heinrich 2012, 44). A service provided for pay is simply a commodity whose production and consumption are not separated either spatially or temporally: they occur at the same time.

a requirement of capitalist production, and a lever by which capital can reconfigure production inputs.

Historically the burden of unremunerated reproductive labor has fallen disproportionately on a gendered and racialized other. However this is not an absolute imposition, and the extent to which racialized and gendered proletarians have had to labor for a diminished wage or no wage at all is a historical question – one that we have tried to answer for early 20th century industrial Michigan. We will briefly recapitulate the results of this study below.

Fordist production, though often considered to be a process of deskilling labor, was in fact a complex reorganization of the relationship between labor and skill. A large portion of the laboring force was assigned decomposed tasks, most of whose required skill resides in complex machinery as dead labor. In a small number of positions such as engineering, managing, or the manufacture of engines, a large amount of skill was required. However most jobs were relatively low-skilled positions such as janitorial work, jobbing or assembly. This stratification did not exist only within individual firms – the increased stratification of the working class is observed across society. As the cities of industrial Michigan grew, the types of available jobs grew as well. A very small portion of workers were considered worthy of a family wage, but most workers survived by combining multiple incomes, or by supplementing substandard incomes with large amounts of subsistence work.

This should not be seen, however, as a simple case of cause-and-effect. Different family and household configurations did not develop in response to set wages. Rather, the larger employers in industrial Michigan systematically created a stratified society by exercising control over the private lives of workers. In the case of the Five Dollar Day, the Ford Motor Company required changes in the configuration of households *before* increased wages would be given. In order for a

worker's labor to be deemed valuable, the worker's family had to disengage from patterns of informal subsistence labor. If they failed to do so, i.e. if the reproduction of their ability to labor continued to be subsidized by informal and non-waged income, then their labor was bought at a lower rate.

In Flint, General Motors took a more direct approach to structuring the private lives of their employees. Through the Modern Housing Corporation, they manipulated not only the family structures associated with higher-valued employees, but the very geography of the city. They used strategic investments to develop patterns of city life. By influencing the location of parks and schools, the planting of trees, and the paving of roads, they structured the reproductive environment of labor, answering Bhattacharya's questions "Does the education [the worker] received at school also not 'produce' her, in that it makes her employable? What about the public transportation system that helped bring her to work, or the public parks and libraries that provide recreation...?" (Bhattacharya 2017, 1-2) with an emphatic *yes*.

But not only the public schools, transit, parks and libraries – private institutions contribute to the reproduction of labor as well. If the domestic labor of a wife or child depressed the value of their husband's or father's labor power, that same work performed by any of the 88% of working Detroit Black women employed in domestic service had the opposite effect: now as a *commodity* contributing to the reproduction of the worker it contributes also to the value of his labor power. In Michigan, the value of domestic and ancillary workers' labor power was systematically depressed by the necessity of subsistence labor in underserved neighborhoods. At the same time, Black and female workers in reproductive jobs propped up the value of what industry considered to be the most important labor – that of white, male, and skilled workers.

The creation of a particular configuration of stratified society is a totally different thing than its maintenance. In this instance, capital and its representatives created certain conditions of social reproduction, but were quick to offload the responsibility at the first opportunity. General Motors transferred the responsibility for paving streets and planting trees to homeowners, and the running of schools and parks to the city of Flint. The management of wage-rates slipped out of the hands of employers with the development of a federal minimum wage as a part of FDR's New Deal, and the rise of a unionized auto industry with the Flint sit-down strike of 1937. It is important to note that both of these institutions, both early 20th century unions and New Deal programs, were more than happy to maintain segregation and a stratified workforce.

The point of this paper is not to directly link a certain type of reproductive scheme with Fordist production. As Gramsci noted, Americanism and its particular configuration of social life would be neither desirable nor possible outside of America. Rather I have attempted to demonstrate ways in which social-reproductive institutions are integrated into schemes of production. The specifics of this integration will change according to the needs of capital, but Social Reproduction Theory provides an excellent, if limited, starting point for their excavation.

Earlier I noted that a full elaboration of industrial Michigan's role in the United States' hegemonic ascent was outside the scope of this paper. The lacuna here is larger than I let on, primarily because "industrial Michigan" is not a neatly bounded object – it is an incoherent object when divorced from the larger structure of the world-system and its globe-spanning commodity chains. Ford's River Rouge plant may have turned raw materials into cars in a single location, but the raw materials did not appear spontaneously at the factory gates. They had to be extracted from the earth by laborers outside of Detroit and shipped to the factory. A continuation of the line of enquiry expressed in this study will have to look along these commodity chains to

truly account for the interlinked relations of production and reproduction supporting early Fordist production. This includes miners in Michigan's upper peninsula, and railway workers along transit routes, but most crucially it includes workers on rubber plantations in South America, Africa, and Colonial Malaya. The study of productive and reproductive relations in the core is incomplete without an accounting of their co-constitution with similar relations in the global periphery. It is in this direction that future work must turn.

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